Iosifescu assumed that other Securitate agents and informers were monitoring him outside the office, too. His expertise with a powerful and potentially subversive technology made him a prime target. But in truth, the paranoid regime of Nicolae Ceauşescu regarded all twenty million Romanian citizens as targets. If it was possible, Ceauşescu would have placed every one of them under constant surveillance. He actually made some steps in that direction. Before he came to power, in 1965, the Securitate had just one electronic surveillance centre in Bucharest and 11 more in provincial cities. By 1978, Bucharest alone was monitored by 10 electronic surveillance centres, 248 centres scrutinised the provinces, and an additional 1,000 portable surveillance units were moved around to eavesdrop on remote villages and holiday resorts.[2]

When, in the late 1970s, Securitate agents discovered that some Romanians were writing anonymous letters to Radio Free Europe criticising the regime, Ceauşescu orchestrated a nationwide effort to collect handwriting samples from *all* twenty million Romanian citizens. Schools and universities were forced to hand in essays from every student. Employers had to ask each employee to submit a handwritten CV and then forward it to the Securitate. 'What about retirees and the unemployed?' asked one of Ceauşescu's aides. 'Invent some kind of new form!' commanded the dictator. 'Something they will have to fill in.' Some of the subversive letters, however, were typed, so Ceauşescu also had every state-owned typewriter in the country registered, with samples filed away in the Securitate archive. People who possessed a private typewriter had to inform the Securitate of it, hand in the typewriter's 'fingerprint' and ask for official authorisation to use it.[3]

But Ceauşescu's regime, just like the Stalinist regime it modelled itself on, could not really follow every citizen twenty-four hours a day. Given that even Securitate agents needed to sleep, it would probably have required at least forty million of them to keep the twenty million Romanian citizens under constant surveillance. Ceauşescu had only about forty thousand Securitate agents.[4] And even if Ceauşescu could somehow conjure up forty million agents, that would only have presented new problems, because the regime needed to monitor its own agents, too. Like Stalin, Ceauşescu distrusted his own agents and officials more than anyone else, especially after his spy chief – Ion Mihai Pacepa – defected to the United States in 1978. Politburo members, high-ranking officials, army generals and